



Longbows in action
At the battle of Aljubarrota in 1385 *(right)* English longbowmen helped the Portuguese defeat the French and Spanish forces. Here, as in many medieval illustrations, most of the archers are shown firing their arrows from the wrong side of the bow. A modern re-enactor *(far right)* demonstrates how the bow should be drawn.

Tournaments were mounted to showcase archers' skills, and statutes were proclaimed banning or limiting other sports and pastimes that might compete with archery. In the 1360s, as well as banning the export of bows and arrows, the king forbade archers to leave England without his express permission, presumably through fear that they might join the armies of his enemies.

CALL TO ARMS

The use of missile weapons, especially bows and arrows, was generally denigrated in medieval European warfare. Knights affected to despise a style of combat that allowed a man to kill from a distance, denouncing it as cowardly and base. As a result, the nobility and gentry did not fight as archers. Bowmen were typically drawn from the middling ranks of society, the small freeholders or "yeomen" – although at times plenty of poorer, less respectable folk undoubtedly filled out the ranks. As well as south Wales, most forested areas of England were major sources of bowmen, as the traditional basic use of archery was for hunting. Since there was no standing army in medieval England, archers were not full-time soldiers but men who undertook to serve for a particular campaign. In an attempt to ensure their quality, royal officials known as commissions of array were entrusted with selecting the best men from those mustered by local sheriffs in the shires. Later in the period, archers were more likely to be enrolled as indentured members of forces that noblemen contracted to supply to the king. On campaign archers were commanded by officers known as centenars, who commanded companies of 100 men, and vintenars who commanded 20. They were paid twice as much as ordinary foot soldiers, so we can assume that they were conscious of a special elite status. Like all other medieval soldiers, they would expect to augment their pay by pillaging or by the ransom of prisoners. Archers would not benefit from being ransomed themselves if captured on the battlefield, however. Despised

The last years of the Hundred Years' War
In this encounter between the French *(left)* and English near Cherbourg in 1450, both sides include longbowmen, but they were no longer the force they had been earlier in the war.

